

You Need To Know What The Tilde (~) Does In Excel

Technology

 December 26, 2025  Admin  Leave A Comment



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Picture this: you need to find or count cells containing asterisks (*) or question marks (?) in Excel, but you’re getting incorrect results. This is because asterisks and question marks are wildcard characters. The solution? Excel’s essential escape character, the tilde (~).

Wildcard and escape characters in Excel

Wildcard characters are symbols that allow you to create flexible search criteria in Excel functions such as COUNTIF or SUMIF , and features such as Find and Replace and filtering. However, to use them accurately, you need to know how to use the escape character—the tilde—to search for the wildcards themselves.

The Excel wildcards

Excel recognizes two primary wildcard characters : the asterisk and the question mark.

Wildcard character

Name

What it represents

Example

Search

Search

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*

Asterisk

Any sequence of characters (including no characters).

Searching for "A*" matches "Apple," "A," and "Accountant."

?

Question mark

Any single character at that position.

Searching for "b?t" matches "bat," "bet," "bit," and "but," but not "boot."

The problem: When wildcards mask literal characters

If your data contains an actual asterisk or question mark, and you try to search for it using a function or a feature that supports wildcards, Excel interprets the symbol as its wildcard meaning, not the literal character.

Imagine you manage an inventory for an electronics store. In your product database, you use an asterisk to signify clearance items.

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G
1	Product	Count	Sales				
2	Laptop*	189	\$ 58,887				
3	PC	358	\$ 55,864				
4	Tablet?	150	\$ 73,186				
5	Accessory	367	\$ 52,952				
6	Phone*	497	\$ 10,549				
7	Charger	279	\$ 28,089				
8	Power bank*	275	\$ 32,501				
9	TV	368	\$ 30,177				
10	Soundbar?	386	\$ 46,474				
11	Console~	332	\$ 49,898				

You want to know exactly how many products are marked for clearance, so in a separate cell, you type:

=COUNTIF(A:A,"*")

=COUNTIF(A:A,"*")

However, the formula counts every non-empty cell in column A because the asterisk is interpreted as "match any sequence of characters."

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You don't truly understand Excel until you know its symbols.

Using the tilde in criteria-based functions

Beyond COUNTIF, the tilde is essential when you use any criteria-based function to search for asterisks and question marks.

Using the same inventory data as before, suppose items flagged with a question mark require special accounting.

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H
1	Product	Count	Sales					
2	Laptop*	189	\$ 58,887					
3	PC	358	\$ 55,864					
4	Tablet?	150	\$ 73,186					
5	Accessory	367	\$ 52,952					
6	Phone*	497	\$ 10,549					
7	Charger	279	\$ 28,089					
8	Power bank*	275	\$ 32,501					
9	TV	368	\$ 30,177					
10	Soundbar?	386	\$ 46,474					
11	Console~	332	\$ 49,898					

Specifically, you want to sum the sales values of all these items. Since the question mark is interpreted as a wildcard character by default, you need to use the escape tilde directly before it in your SUMIF formula:

```
=SUMIF(A:A,"*~?",C:C)
```

```
=SUMIF(A:A, "*~?", C:C)
```

Here, the asterisk is used as a wildcard character because it isn't preceded by a tilde. This means that it matches any sequence of characters at the beginning of the item code. However, the tilde-question mark sequence is interpreted as a literal question mark.

As a result, the entire criteria tells Excel to sum the values in column C for any item code in column A that ends with the literal question mark.

F2								
	A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H
1	Product	Count	Sales					
2	Laptop*	189	\$ 58,887	Special sales	\$278,332			
3	PC	358	\$ 55,864					
4	Tablet?	150	\$ 73,186					
5	Accessory	367	\$ 52,952					
6	Phone*	497	\$ 10,549					
7	Charger	279	\$ 28,089					
8	Power bank*	275	\$ 32,501					
9	TV	368	\$ 30,177					

Finding and replacing asterisks and question marks

Excel's Find and Replace tool (Ctrl+H) also recognizes wildcards. Just as in formulas, if you want to target a literal asterisk or question mark, you must use the tilde to escape the wildcard function.

Imagine you have completed the special accounting in the example above, and you now want to remove the question marks.

Since the question marks are only part of the character strings rather than the entire cell contents, make sure "Match entire cell contents" is unchecked in the Find and Replace dialog.

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G
1	Product	Count	Sales				
2	Laptop*	189	\$ 58,887				
3	PC	358	\$ 55,864				
4	Tablet?	150	\$ 73,186				
5	Accessory	367	\$ 52,952				
6	Phone*	497	\$ 10,549				
7	Charger	279	\$ 28,089				
8	Power bank*	275	\$ 32,501				
9	TV	368	\$ 30,177				
10	Soundbar?	386	\$ 46,474				
11	Console~	332	\$ 49,898				

Find and Replace

Find

Replace

Find what:

Replace with:

Within:

Sheet

Search:

By Rows

Look in:

Formulas

Match case

Match entire cell contents

Options <<

Replace All

Replace

Find All

Find Next

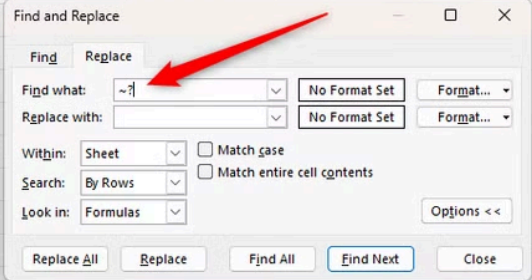
Close

Typing ? or *? into the Find What field and leaving the Replace With field blank replaces all the contents of all the cells with blanks (in other words, you'll get a whole data loss).

The only safe way to target only the literal question mark is by using the tilde (~?), and leaving the Replace With criteria blank tells Excel to replace this combination

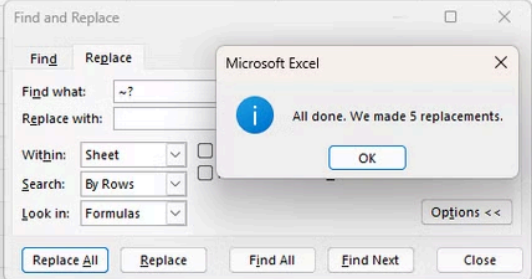
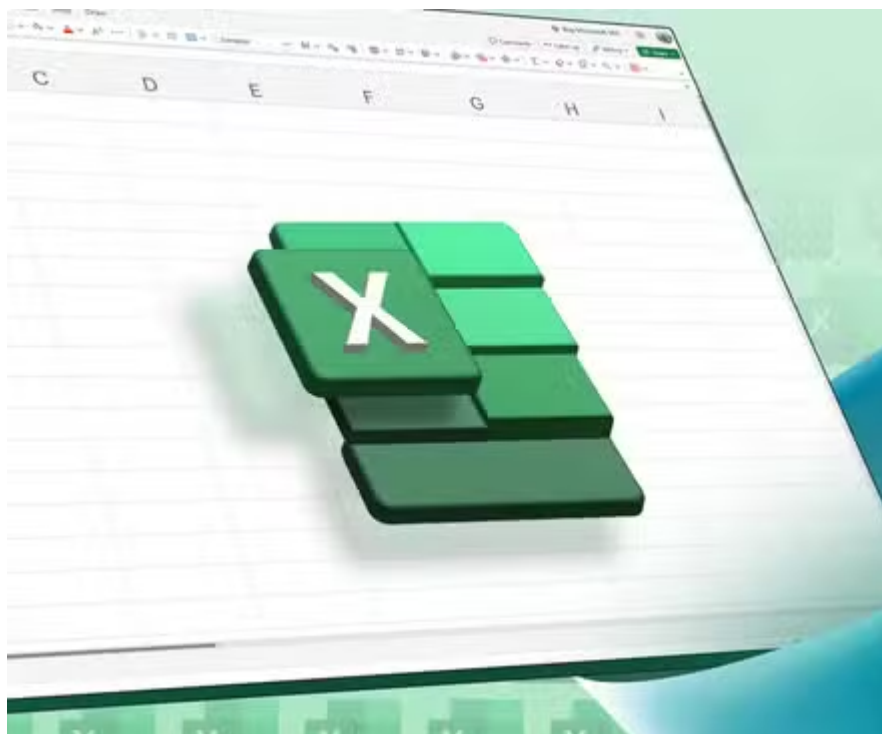
with blanks, which is the same as a deletion.

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G
1	Product	Count	Sales				
2	Laptop*	189	\$ 58,887				
3	PC	358	\$ 55,864				
4	Tablet?	150	\$ 73,186				
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10	Soundbar?	386	\$ 46,474				
11	Console~	332	\$ 49,898				

The image shows the 'Find and Replace' dialog box in Microsoft Excel. The 'Find' tab is selected. The 'Find what' field contains '~?', which is highlighted by a red arrow. The 'Replace with' field is empty. The 'Within' dropdown is set to 'Sheet', 'Search' is 'By Rows', and 'Look in' is 'Formulas'. The 'Match case' and 'Match entire cell contents' checkboxes are unchecked. The 'Options' button is visible on the right. At the bottom, there are buttons for 'Replace All', 'Replace', 'Find All', 'Find Next', and 'Close'.

As a result, when you click “Replace All,” all the string-end question marks are successfully removed.

	A	B	C	D	E	F	G
1	Product	Count	Sales				
2	Laptop*	189	\$ 58,887				
3	PC	358	\$ 55,864				
4	Tablet	150	\$ 73,186				
5	Accessory	367	\$ 52,952				
6	Phone*	497	\$ 10,549				
7	Charger	279	\$ 28,089				
8	Power bank*	275	\$ 32,501				
9	TV	368	\$ 30,177				
10	Soundbar	386	\$ 46,474				
11	Console~	332	\$ 49,898				

The image shows the 'Find and Replace' dialog box in Microsoft Excel, similar to the previous one. However, a 'Microsoft Excel' information dialog box is overlaid on top of it. The message in the dialog box says 'All done. We made 5 replacements.' with an 'OK' button. The 'Find and Replace' dialog box is still visible in the background, showing the same settings as before.

Choose the best way to find corresponding values.

Filtering data with asterisks and question marks

When you use Excel’s built-in filtering tools, the searches also recognize asterisks and question marks as wildcards. Using the tilde is the only way to isolate data

containing the literal characters.

How-To Geek Report

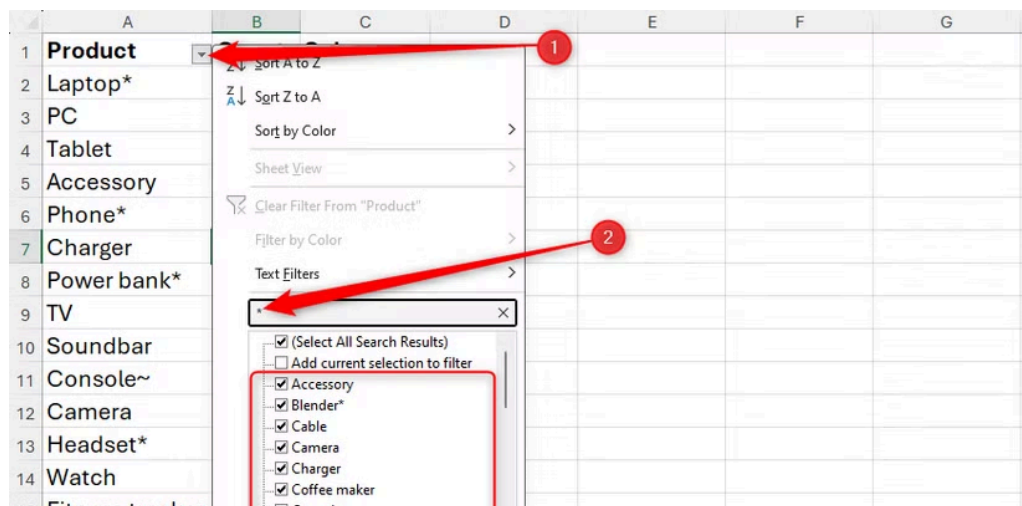
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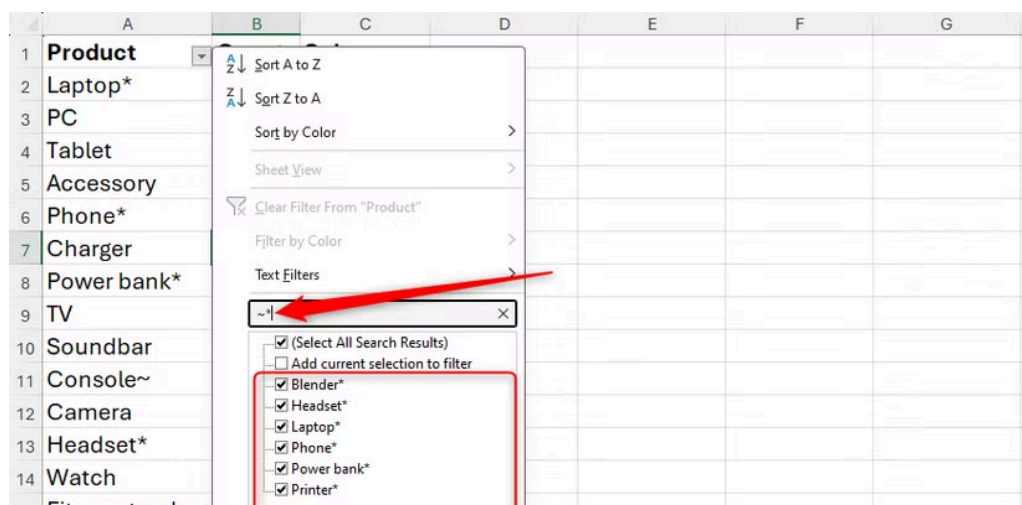
Suppose you want to filter all the items in your inventory so that you only see the items containing an asterisk.

Select any cell in the dataset and click "Filter" in the Data bar to add filter buttons. Alternatively, format the range as an Excel table to add filter buttons automatically.

If you type * into the filter search field, or click Text Filters > Contains and type *, Excel will return all the items, including those without an asterisk, as the asterisk is considered a wildcard representing any sequence of characters.



So, to instruct Excel to find only the literal asterisk, type the escape character directly within the filter criteria.



This successfully isolates the items containing an asterisk.

Escaping the escape character: Finding the tilde itself

So, the asterisk and question marks are the wildcards, and the tilde is the escape character. But what do you do when the literal character you need to find or count is the tilde itself? The principle remains exactly the same: you must escape the character's special function by typing two tildes.

This sequence works identically across all three features I've covered:

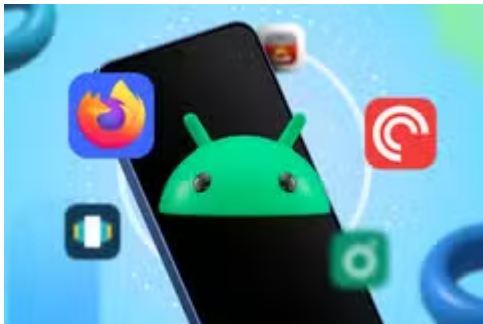
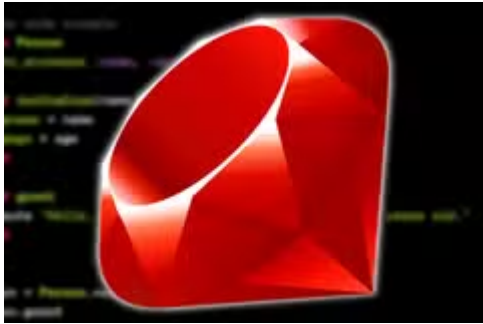
The tilde isn't the only sign you need to understand to truly get your head around Excel's inner workings. For example, the at (@) sign returns a single row value instead of spilling an array, the hash (#) sign allows formulas to adjust to changes in spilled range sizes, and the double-unary operator (–) converts Boolean values to numeric ones.



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